

This enormous watery region consists of the island continent of Australia, the large island groups of New Zealand and Papua New Guinea, and 11 independent island nations and other territories strung out across the vast distances of the southern Pacific Ocean.

The center of Australia is known as the Outback and is one of the hottest, driest areas on Earth. Most of the Outback consists of sandy or stony desert, dotted with mountain ranges and a few rocky outcrops, including Uluru, or Ayers Rock, the world's largest free-standing rock.

